



(FROM LEFT) A.B. BARDHAN, JAYALALITHAA AND PRAKASH KARAT

AP PHOTO

Prakash Karat

CPI(M)

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- Can easily gather at least 40 seats in his kitty, thanks to the CPI(M)'s traditional strongholds.
- He can act as a negotiator among a number of regional parties which can't see eye to eye.
- He will be the most sought-after ally for any front that makes the last stretch run to the 272 mark.

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- His prestige may take a beating if his Third Front partners leave for the BJP or the Congress alliance.
- In spite of being the leading light of the TF, he is unsure if his party will join a Third Front government.
- Party colleagues may force him to support a Congress-led government to keep the BJP away.

unsaid part is: well, it could be the Empress of Poes Garden herself. After all, the lady is pretty flexible in spirit. If the Congress gets ahead and needs her to form the government, Jaya may lend her hand. She hopes she can eventually dislodge Karunanidhi from chief ministership, which he enjoys with the Congress' help. If the BJP gets past the post, Jaya won't hesitate to be a partner either. Sensing that sops like the ration rice for Re 1 per kilo and free TV have added to Karunanidhi's popularity, she has latched on to the emotional issue of Sri Lankan Tamils. A shaken Karunanidhi told a TV channel: "The leader of LTTE, Prabhakaran is my friend. He is not a terrorist. If he dies in battle I would be a sad person." He would later take refuge in the usual I-have-been-misquoted refrain.

Next door, Karnataka's "humble farmer" and former prime minister H.D. Deve Gowda, 76, may not be expecting a bumper crop but the JD-S chief is determined to have a bigger say in Delhi this time. The farmer too is a flexible politician who is capable of flirting with both the Congress and the Third Front. Gowda, in his autumnal years, is still a prisoner of celestial constellations. An astrologer in

KARAT COLLECTED HIS ASSETS WHILE MANMOHAN WAS BUSY WITH THE NUCLEAR DEAL AND KEPT AWAY FROM REAL POLITIK.

heart, is already glowing in the "secular" sheen of the Third Front. The Nitish Kumar-led JD(U) is under bigger compulsion to keep off the BJP and the elections may give him enough courage to part ways.

There is an extended line-up of prime minister hopefuls, with BSP supremo Mayawati leading the pack. She is hard-selling herself as the country's first Dalit prime minister. Unlike other Third Front prime minister wannabes who have never made their wishes obvious, Mayawati has gone public with her dream. She may not be a favourite of the chattering classes but in Uttar Pradesh, if she can replicate her performance of the last assembly elections—though a difficult task—she will end up winning 50 crucial seats. Down south, AIADMK supremo J. Jayalalithaa, another diva of soaring ambition, was in a kind of

year-long hibernation at her leafy Kodanadu estates in the Ooty Hills after the devastating humiliation in the 2006 assembly elections. Royally ignored by the UPA chief Sonia Gandhi, Jayalalithaa now has a two-pronged strategy. One is to build a strong alliance and face the elections. Of the 40 Lok Sabha seats in Tamil Nadu and Puducherry, the AIADMK contests in 23, its new ally PMK in seven, the Left in six and Vaiko's MDMK in four. Amma on the stump makes her mission clear: "If you vote for the AIADMK and its allies, Tamil Nadu will get to decide who will be India's next prime minister." The

Hassan, his hometown, has told him that the country is heading for a hung Parliament. "Post-poll India will be interesting to watch," says Gowda. The first man from Karnataka to become prime minister is hoping that history will work for him once more. In neighbouring Andhra Pradesh, guided not by stars but by his instincts, the TDP leader Naidu has changed tack this time. He has aligned with the communists and the TRS—all of them were the Congress allies in 2004, a cruel year for the former reformer chief minister. In May, if the number of TDP MPs is relatively better than other re-